Under the sponsorship of the National Endowment for the Humanities, a group of doctoral students under the direction of folklorist Richard Dorson of Indiana University's Folklore Institute conducted a folklore field investigation into ~~the forays of~~ the Calumet Region of Northwestern Indiana. The two year project specifically sought to "gather and prepare materials on urban folklore--texts, syllabuses, slides, audio and video tapes, and recordings designed for classroom use." The scope of the project into "Da Region" as it is popularly called was to inquire about five areas of contemporary urban folklore: folklore about the Region itself; the folklore of steel ~~since the industry dominates the area;~~ the folklore of ethnic groups; the folklore of crime and the Black folklore. In addition, the grant allowed for a conference on urban folklore held at Indiana University at the completion of the grant in the fall of 1977 in which the results of the project were presented to an interdisciplinary panel of urban specialists.

The leading center of the Region, Gary, Indiana was founded in 1906 and built on sand dunes to house steelworkers for the industry which still dominates the area. A whole cluster of associations stamping the Region giving it the image of a crime ridden and polluted area. For example, brave adventurers into Da Region often are asked whether they are taking a gun or increasing their life insurance. Others of the area view Gary in another light; the Blacks view Gary as a city on the move with the election of Mayor Richard Hatcher

the first Black mayor elected in an Eastern city.

Gary, Indiana and its sprawling bedroom communities represents a focus for contemporary urban folklorists as well as an example of metroplitan American life. Dominated by the steel industry, the industry and its workers ~~spurn~~ produce a folklore - a folklore of the "Mill-rats" analogous to Moody Boatright's Folklore of the Oil Industry. The high concentration of ethnic groups in the area (Serbs, Croats, Mexicans, Puerto Ricnas, Greeks, Poles, Macedonians, Romanians) over eighty in total produce a high counsciousness of ethnic awareness evidenced by public and community events, local ethnic shops and restaurants each displaying traditions and customs brought from their respective countries and those which have been partly assimilated into the American scene.

As in most representative cities, people are concenred ~~xi~~ with how crime affects thier life, and consequently a folklore evolves from thier experiences. Traditional motifs in crime related incidents collected in the region serve as a foundation for a contemporary urban crime folklore.

A diversity of opinion within the region exists in regard to the area's image. While Blacks view the city as one undergoing urban renweal and growing; whites flee from the downtown Area.

~~Under the sponsorh~~